

ALL YOU NEED TO KNOW

Japan is spread over an area of 377,873 square kilometers, nearly equivalent to Germany and Switzerland combined or slightly smaller than California. Japan consists of four major islands – Hokkaido (northern island), Honshu (main island), Shikoku (smallest island) and Kyushu (southern island) -- surrounded by more than 4,000 smaller islands.

Like many developed countries, Japan can be an expensive place to visit if you don't plan ahead. However, there are a wide variety of budget accommodation options, transportation passes and sightseeing discounts, which help to make Japan an affordable destination for even the most budget conscious traveler.

Japan abounds in accommodations, both western-style and Japanese. Types of accommodation vary widely in terms of style and price. You can choose to stay in the familiar comforts of a western-style hotel, or enjoy the comfort and personal attention of a traditional Japanese inn. By taking time to search out some of the nation's less-publicized types of lodgings, you're sure to find clean and comfortable places to stay that suit your pocket.

With the Japan Rail Pass, foreign visitors to Japan can enjoy discounted travel on nearly all services of the extensive JR Transportation Network, including the Shinkansen or 'bullet train'. Long distances buses and local train services are other low-cost transport options. You must buy a Japan Rail pass from India if you are visiting Japan as it offers cheap train travel not only within Tokyo on JR metro but you can also travel to major cities like Osaka in the "bullet train" on the same pass.

Taxis in Japan are expensive so long taxi rides are best avoided. But Japan's efficient and affordable local transportation networks mean that taxis are rarely required.

Many foreign visitors mistakenly believe that it is very expensive in Tokyo but this is not really true. Many visitors know about "100-yen Shops" and enjoy shopping at these and other discount shops, while dining out is also becoming more affordable. Some would go to soba (Buckwheat noodles) shops to have tempura

(Deep-fried in vegetable oil, fish and vegetables) soba noodles, rather than going to tempura shops only to order tempura. Also, they go in a group to enjoy sharing nabe (pan menu).

Restaurant dining in Tokyo is no more expensive than in most other world capitals. Follow the locals and you will generally find both lower prices and more authentic Japanese cuisine. Avoid restaurants that don't list their prices outside the door. Budget dining can usually be enjoyed at more casual establishments such as Izakaya (Japanese pubs), Shokudo (general eating places, often with set meals), and Okonomiyaki restaurants ('Japanese pizza' places).

If you are planning a trip to Japan before by August, carry only light clothes (cardigans and other similar kinds are handy, since indoors are mostly air-conditioned) as it is quite hot and humid in July and August. Autumn starts in September and lasts till November. It brings freshness with a light breeze and cool temperature after the hot and humid summer. Don't forget to carry light jackets and light sweaters. Winter (December-February) can be very cold though temperatures rarely drop below zero degree celcius. It is advisable to carry a overcoat along with sweaters.

The best season to visit is Spring (March-May), when Tokyo and areas around it bloom with cherry blossom flowers. You can make do with light sweaters and light jackets during this season.

Currency and Money Exchange

The unit of Japanese currency is Yen. The exchange rate of Yen at present is around 105 to a US dollar. Coins are available in denominations of 1, 5, 10, 50, 100 and 500 yen and bank notes in denominations of 1,000, 2,000, 5,000 and 10,000 yen.

Drinking water

Tap water is safe to drink anywhere in Japan. Mineral water including major imported brands can be easily obtained from super markets and convenience stores.



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